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MADAGASCAR LAUNCH
CENTRAL ATRIUM

11 APR
7 PM ONWARDS
THE BEAR HOUSE
LAUNCH
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12 APR
6 PM ONWARDS
SING ALONG
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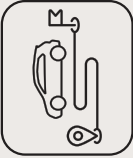


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pick of the week



Millennial mind

G.O.A.T (Grotesque Of All Time), a solo dance-theatre work by Maitreyee Joshi, unravels the uneasy pursuit of greatness through a millennial lens. The piece slips between movement and monologue, tracing the impostor syndrome, self-doubt and humour. Blurring dance and theatre, it offers a raw, often absurd portrait of ambition, mediocrity and becoming. *On April 19, from 7pm onwards at The Stage, Alwarpet. Tickets on bookmyshow.in*



Shop, sip, stroll

LocalXO marks its 25th Sunday Market pop-up with a lively, sunlit edition at Bungalow 12, Adyar — a glasshouse filled with food, shopping, and good energy. Expect everything from biryani and kebabs, sandos and global bites, plus desserts and matcha. Browse brands like Churned Ice Cream, Bleddy Burgers, Yettu Craft Coffee, Novavii Makeup, Mon Chéri by Girika, and many more. *On April 12, at the Bungalow, Adyar, 12pm onwards.*



Korea on a plate

Bringing the buzz of Korean street food to the table, Little Soi presents Mukbang!, a limited-edition menu centred on Korean flavours and shareable plates. The spread includes twi gim, mandu, pajeon, dakgangjeong, crispy lamb ganjang, corn dog, kalbi skewers, kkakdugi kimchi ramen, doenjang-jjigae, jajangmyeon and the bulgogi set, bringing together familiar staples from the country's bustling food culture. *Till April 21 at Little Soi outlets across the city.*



Paint a memory

Tribe Talk brings Iyarkayin Kadhaigal an evening of memory and making. Recall waves, open skies, birds — whatever stayed with you — and paint it in a notebook. The session drifts between sketching, storytelling and conversation. Share your Nature stories and meet a community of Nature lovers. Notebooks and artsupplies given by the venue. *Starting ₹1,099 on April 11 from 4pm to 8pm at Backyard, Adyar. Register at beacons.ai*



AT THE TABLE

Karan Gokani

Authenticity is one of those words that now gets thrown around so often that it has started to mean very little. It gives the speaker an air of authority, especially when backed by loose claims to personal heritage, and suggests they are protecting something irreplaceable. In reality, it is usually doing far less useful work than people imagine. I understand why the word matters to people. Food carries memory, migration, class, geography, religion, and family history. A dish can remind you of your grandmother, your hometown or a loss. As an immigrant myself, I get why people feel protective of that. But today, authenticity feels less of a thoughtful conversation and more like a performance. The word is used less as a genuine defence of culture and more often as a tool for status. Some people build platforms around it, becoming crusaders of authenticity, appointing themselves as judge and jury over who is allowed to cook what, how far they may stray, and whether they have earned the right to speak. Very often, the reward for doing this is popularity. You can gain a

The authenticity trap

If your grandmother made a dish one way and mine made it another, whose version wins? Authenticity is more about power than truth

following by standing in front of a dish and declaring it inauthentic, particularly if you can wrap that criticism in heritage, identity or moral certainty. It is a powerful position to occupy, and like most powerful positions, it is often abused. My problem is that authenticity is relative. If your grandmother made a dish one way and mine made it another, whose version wins? If a recipe changes from one village to the next what exactly are we protecting? So much of what

people describe as authentic is simply familiar. It is what they grew up with, what they were told was correct, what feels emotionally true to them. That matters, of course, but it is not an objective standard. Recipes that were once guarded, regional, handwritten or passed down orally are now one click away. You can watch a home cook in Chennai make a pepper fry, a

A dish can remind you of your grandmother, your hometown or a loss; (below) Chef Jamie Oliver. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK AND AFP

grandmother in Palermo shape pasta, or a ramen chef in Tokyo prepare broth, all while eating your beans on toast for breakfast. Creators now share everything from magic tricks to restaurant recipes online, for free. Some people see that as a loss of mystique. I think it is also a remarkable kind of generosity. That is partly why I would rather the Jamie Olivers of the world make a simplified version of an Indian dish for their audience than avoid it altogether for the fear of offending the authenticity police. His viewers may never buy my cookbooks, follow me online, or step into one of my restaurants. But if Jamie's first version sparks curiosity, and they begin to dig deeper, then there is a better chance that one day, once their interest grows, they might want something more rooted, more detailed, more regionally specific. That is why I insisted on real Indian recipes rather than authentic Indian recipes for



my cookbook *Indian 101*. Real felt more honest. Claiming authenticity across a country the size and complexity of India seemed slightly mad, not to mention a good way to have several aunts, chefs and home cooks on the Internet telling me I was wrong. And what about innovation? Friends of mine in Mumbai, Delhi and elsewhere are using western and East Asian techniques to express Indian flavours in delicious new ways. Think of places like Masque, Indian Accent, Papa's or Bombay Canteen. At the same time, bakers, pizzaiolos and pastry chefs are creating brilliant western forms with local Indian ingredients. This is not blasphemy. It is simply culture doing what it has always done, adapting, absorbing and evolving. For those who want to preserve tradition, the Internet can help with that too. We are documenting real recipes, methods and voices in a way earlier generations could never imagine. So yes, there will always be noise around authenticity and cultural appropriation. But I increasingly feel that if someone butchers a dish and lazily calls it authentic, they are unlikely to get away with it. A quick search can usually tell you when someone has simply dressed up ignorance as authority. I do not think every bad version of a dish requires a public crusade. I am far more interested in good faith, proper credit, real curiosity and delicious food. That feels more worthwhile than another circular argument over a word. In the end, authenticity, for me, has less to do with rigid rules and more to do with intention. *Karan Gokani is a London-based chef, restaurateur and author who writes on food, travel and hospitality, driven by a curiosity about what the world is eating.*



(Clockwise from left) Nicky Chandam's Unfolded; art by Arindam Manna; and Shehzor with Inshallah Babes. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



S Poorvaja

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Bringing together a diverse range of practices and perspectives from artists across the country, the Sumanasa Foundation will present Art Unfettered, a two-day showcase on April 12 and 13 in Chennai. Now in its second year, musician, author and activist TM Krishna who helms the foundation, traces their journey and the decision to begin the Grants Project which invites applications from artists pushing the envelope. “We felt that there were young artistes we could support and encourage through a grant, to think in a far more open manner in terms of their craft... This is in keeping with a philosophy that art needs to engage with larger society and the complexity of socio-political issues,” Krishna says. He emphasises the importance of democratising grants in the art world, which are most often urban- and English-centric. “We spread the word through posters in multiple languages and local artistes in other states. We did not insist on written applications either; videos and even voice notes were encouraged, whatever they were the most comfortable with,” he explains. While the foundation received

A not-so-still life

Sumanasa Foundation's Art Unfettered has five artistes breaking boundaries take the stage



nearly 150 applications from across the country, five artistes, Seetha, Arindam Manna, Nicky Chandam, Rini Alphonsa Joseph, and Shehzor and her rock band, Inshallah Babes, were then chosen by an independent jury. After being awarded a grant, every artiste has, over the last nine months, worked on their existing, or a newer body of work, with Art Unfettered being a culmination of this.

On day 1, Seetha, a PhD scholar will present a solo act, Kathakali, at 5.30pm; visual artiste Arindam will be in conversation with Aishwarya Arumbakkam at 6.45pm and Nicky will present Unfolding: A Free Verse Movement at 7.45pm. On day 2, artist, potter and writer Rini will be in conversation with V Saranraj at 6.30pm, and Shehzor and her independent band will perform at 7.30pm.

The last few months, visual artiste Arindam says, took him back to the forests of Suri, his hometown in West Bengal, and made him ponder over the realities of extinction and how the places he had grown up in have changed over the years. “I have always been interested in the transitional phase of a place, and this project documents these fragile forests through a range of visual art based on my jottings, recordings and photographs from interacting with the communities there,” he explains. Seetha's Kathakali delves into conversations on love between the self and the world. Working on this, she says, was a loving community process. “Many of us are not full-time artistes and we tap into art and spaces that will enhance our work,” she adds. Varisha Narayanan, part of the core team of Sumanasa Foundation with Shweta Prachande and Vignesh Ishwar, says that the foundation values being able to give artistes a safe space to present their work. She adds, “Though they are individual in their journeys, presenting them on the same stage binds them as a cohort.”

Art Unfettered is on April 12-13 at the MS Subbulakshmi Auditorium, Asian College of Journalism, Taramani.

Murder, he wrote

Former advertising man Mohan Menon's new novel takes its protagonists across Kolkata in search of a ninja

Priyadarshini Paitandy

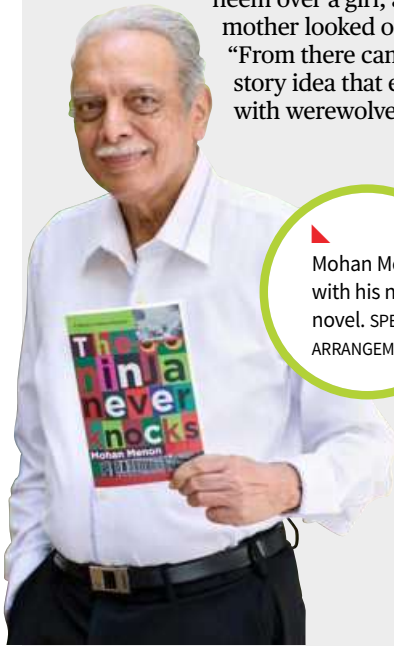
priyadarshini.p@thehindu.co.in

Mohan Menon kills people as he goes along. Thankfully, only in his fictional world. The former advertising savant (he was one of the members of the board at Ogilvy and retired after 32 years with the firm) is an author now. In real life, he is a jovial man, with a repertoire of dad jokes, and eyes sparkling with ideas. How then, does someone like him come up with dark stories and murder mysteries? “It comes from what I see around and some just pop up in my head,” smiles Mohan, who has just launched his detective novel, *The Ninja Never Knocks* (published by Adisakrit). His previous work — *Nail in the Pillow* — was a collection of short stories published in 2020. When Mohan embarked on this journey as an author, he says it was like opening Pandora's box. Ideas kept coming to him. “I wanted them to fly,” he says. He used to go for walks to a university nearby, where he saw an old man waving a branch of neem over a girl, as her mother looked on. “From there came a story idea that ended with werewolves in

it,” he laughs. That was part of his first book. A couple of years later, that itch to write surfaced again. And he started work on *The Ninja Never Knocks*. Mohan's novel is set in Kolkata — the city that has seen iconic fictional detectives like Satyajit Ray's Feluda, and Sharadindu Bandyopadhyay's Byomkesh Bakshi. His friends did point that out but Mohan was determined to have the City of Joy as the backdrop to the action. His Bengali detective is a suave man named Bikram Banerji aka Bando, who flies down from London to Kolkata after his father's demise. Here, he is saddled with his father's chemical plant that he sells and then goes through a hedonistic phase before his girlfriend cuts him down to size. “Bikram likes to read and every book he reads he is able to detect who the culprit is in 100 pages. So, he starts writing novels too,” says Mohan, offering a peek into the world of Bando. Soon, people think since Bando is such a great writer of the detective genre, he must be a detective himself. “The Calcutta police start invoking him. Bando starts getting involved in cases. He also has an assistant, Sabina Sahani. Together, they set out to solve the case of the ninja who is terrorising the city. The ninja enables people to satisfy their bloodthirsty whims. That's his job. He's given his contracts via the dark web,” he says. Despite Bando and Sabina's fights, they stick together. After barking up many wrong trees they manage to unearth who the ninja is. “There are many twists, red herrings, and a bit of history from 1852,” says Mohan. When Mohan started writing this story, he admits he did not have an ending in mind. There were many changes and iterations. “I had to introduce an extra character half way through to create an ending,” he says, and adds, “I build as I go along.”

The Ninja Never Knocks is available at bookstores and online.

Mohan Menon with his new novel. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT





Seoul meets body

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Cherry blossoms are in bloom, and there is palpable excitement across South Korea as BTS kicks off its Arirang concert tour in Goyang, a satellite city of Seoul.

While fans from across the world have converged to see the K-pop supergroup's comeback concerts, the country is also teeming with visitors who are looking to make the most of the season.

Seoul's cherry blossoms are set to peak this week. There are iconic sites like Gyeongbokgung Palace and Cheong Wa Dae (the

President's residence), as well as slower pleasures like a Han River picnic at sunset, or reading by the Cheonggyecheon stream on every Seoul itinerary.

But our guide to the city attempts to take you beyond the predictable highlights; eat the best hotteok, load up on cute art and beauty supplies, and then make a K-Pop

star-worthy video. So download Naver maps on your phone (Google maps do not work well in Korea), recharge your T-Money card for public transport, grab a sweet potato latte, and read on.

The writer was in Seoul on invitation from Korea Tourism Organization

PHOTOS: GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK AND NETFLIX



A street view of the 'Old Street' (Old Town) in Taipei, showing traditional shops and a large tree. The street is paved with cobblestones and has a large tree on the left side. The shops are traditional and have signs in Chinese. The street is lined with buildings and trees, and there are people walking on the street.

A collection of small, round, golden-brown samples of various types of tobacco, each labeled with a name and a small logo. The samples are arranged in rows on a dark surface. The labels include names like "Fleur de Tabac", "Tobacco", and "Tobacco".

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Designer JJ Valaya (far right) unveils his brand's first-ever handbag collection, adorned with semi-precious stone embellishments crafted in collaboration with master artisans from Jaipur. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



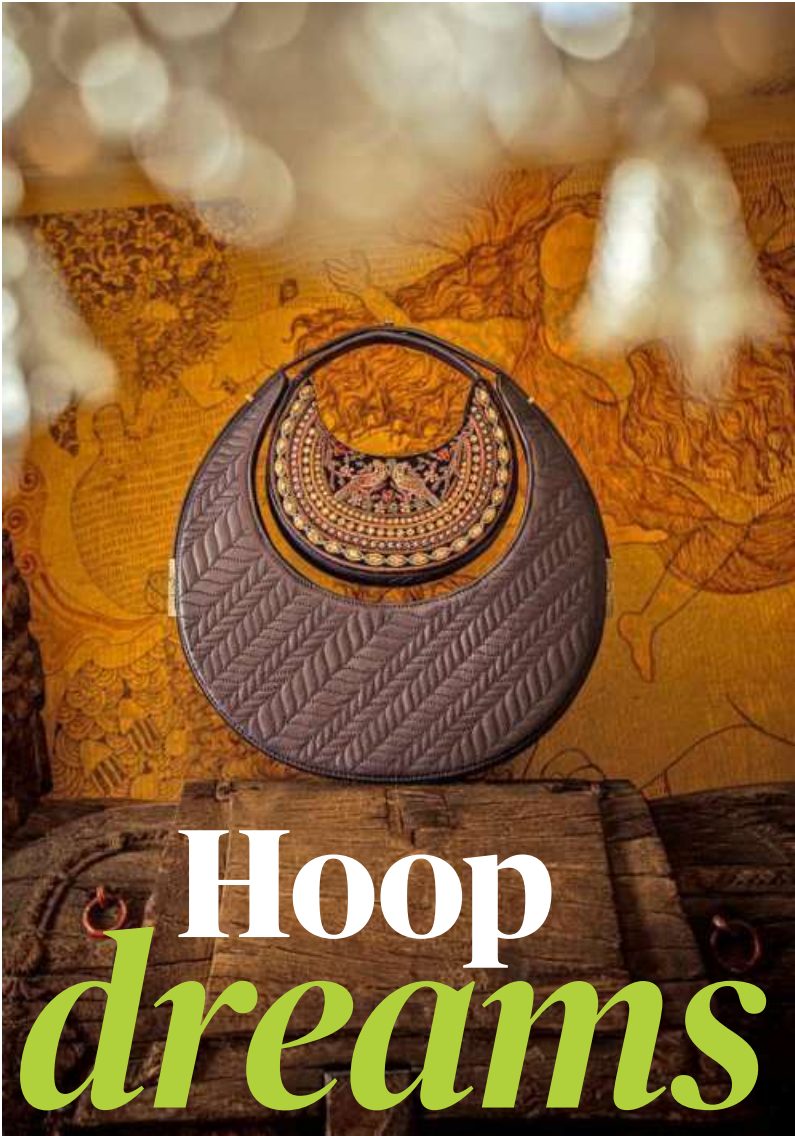
Geetika Sachdev

For JJ Valaya, fashion has always been about storytelling – of journeys, dynasties and craft traditions that stretch across centuries. Now, as his label approaches 35 years, the designer is expanding that narrative into accessories. The newly-launched JJ Valaya Accessories marks the house's first dedicated handbag line, with styles like an oversized velvet clutch, a mini flap bag, a contemporary batua belt bag, and the Raj-Jagjit bag, which carries a deeply personal story. For Valaya, the move felt instinctive. "Historically, for any fashion brand, extending into accessories becomes a natural progression," he says. "Over the years, our clientele has asked for pieces that carry the same sense of heritage and recognisability – but may not necessarily be a full garment." Handbags, he explains, offered a way to translate the label's design language into something more functional. "A couture garment might come out on special occasions, but a bag becomes part of your everyday identity. You could be



dressed in something very simple and modern, and a statement bag can transform the entire look."

Craft at the core Valaya has long described himself as a student of history and craft, and that sensibility remains central to the line. The bags – presented in jewel-toned shades of emerald, burgundy, midnight blue and ivory – are crafted in materials such as velvet and quilted leather, with suede-lined interiors. Their surfaces are richly detailed with



Hoop dreams

As JJ Valaya's label turns 35, the new accessories line translates the designer's signature embroideries and heritage influences into statement bags

embroideries executed in resham thread, sequins, crystals and zardosi. Semi-precious stone embellishments are developed in collaboration with specialist artisans in Jaipur. "We do museum-quality embroideries," Valaya says. "India has some of the finest artisans in the world, and there is absolutely no reason not to celebrate that. Even the great European houses rely heavily on Indian craftsmanship."

For the designer, luxury must also carry the promise of longevity. "When you invest in a beautiful object, you want to use it again and again, perhaps even pass it on," he says. "That is the joy of finding a vintage piece from a great fashion house – it still feels special decades later." At the centre of the collection is perhaps its most emotional piece, The Raj-Jagjit bag, named after the designer's parents.



A couture garment might come out on special occasions, but a bag becomes part of your everyday identity

JJ VALAYA
Fashion designer

The design consists of two connected bags that can also be used separately. The larger Jagjit bag represents his father, while the smaller Raj bag symbolises his mother. "You carry them together almost like an embrace," Valaya explains. "The larger one becomes the protective presence around the smaller one." The tribute reflects the influence his parents had on his life and work.



His mother, he recalls, spent time teaching embroidery techniques at Army welfare centres, while his father, an Army officer, instilled a strong sense of discipline. "They were the foundation of everything that shaped me," he says. "So naming the bags after them was really a way of preserving that memory and honouring their values." The idea for the design had existed for years. "I sketched it almost five years ago," he adds. "I always knew that if I ever started an accessories line, this had to be the piece that began the journey."

The modern heirloom Beyond individual designs, Valaya sees the collection as part of a broader philosophy, creating what he calls "modern heirlooms". He believes modernity has little to do with fleeting fashion cycles. "Modernity is often misunderstood as following trends," he says. "But true elegance comes from having a strong sense of identity, knowing who you are and how you want to present yourself." With the label already developing future collections for upcoming seasons, the handbag line appears set to become a lasting new chapter in Valaya's design journey.

The handbags, priced ₹39,000 onwards, are available at JJ Valaya stores in Delhi and Mumbai, as well as online at valaya.com

Inspired by Maharani Gayatri Devi, Maheka Mirpuri's new edit features sportswear ranging from hand-painted jackets to embroidered suspenders, with a hint of royalty

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The dusty-rose, lace-trimmed folding fan paired with corsets, hoodies and trainers by Fenty x Puma at 2016 Paris Fashion Week marked Rihanna's playful imagining of Marie Antoinette at the gym, reigniting fashion's fascination with blending aristocratic glamour and athletic ease. The dialogue, first shaped by Alexander McQueen and Vivienne Westwood in the 1990s, echoed in Burberry's four-piece capsule collection launched last month as a centenary tribute to Queen Elizabeth II. Now, Mumbai-based designer Maheka Mirpuri drives the narrative home with a collection that envisions a modern maharani – inspired by the third maharani consort of Jaipur (1940 to 1949) Gayatri Devi – stepping onto the pickleball or padel court. Called Maharani Athleisure, the Spring/Summer 2026 edit is an extension of the designer's Fall/Winter Deepavali collection Modern Maharani; though birthed by the same inspiration, both stamp a distinct signature on the design register. "Gayatri Devi was my inspiration for Modern Maharani and I have always been inspired by the quiet strength and the inner grace of a maharani," Maheka says. While elaborating on striking a balance between the collection's elevated design and comfort, she first mentions the zippers. She



Don't sweat it, maharani!



says, "Zippers instantly give a sporty feel. The collection comprises chunky, hand-painted jackets with acrylic paint and floral embroidery. They also feature Swarovski embellishments, ornate brooches and embroidered buttons." The limited-edition collection comprising 86 garments also brings to mind American designer Jeremy Scott's creatives for Adidas Originals, 2010, where he staged royal iconography on athleisure garments. In Maharani Athleisure the iconography leans into popular culture with Mexican artist Frida Kahlo's portrait on a deep orange jacket. There are several other techniques central to the collection, which build on rococo floral aesthetics too. "The collection has fabric rosettes. We've done them on the bolero jacket, in organza net. You'll also notice thick chains on these jackets and

(Clockwise from left) Models sporting suspenders from Maharani Athleisure; motifs like safety pins and buttons on suspenders define Maheka's idea of boho; a portrait of Mexican artist Frida Kahlo on a deep orange jacket; and an oversized, chunky jacket from the edit. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



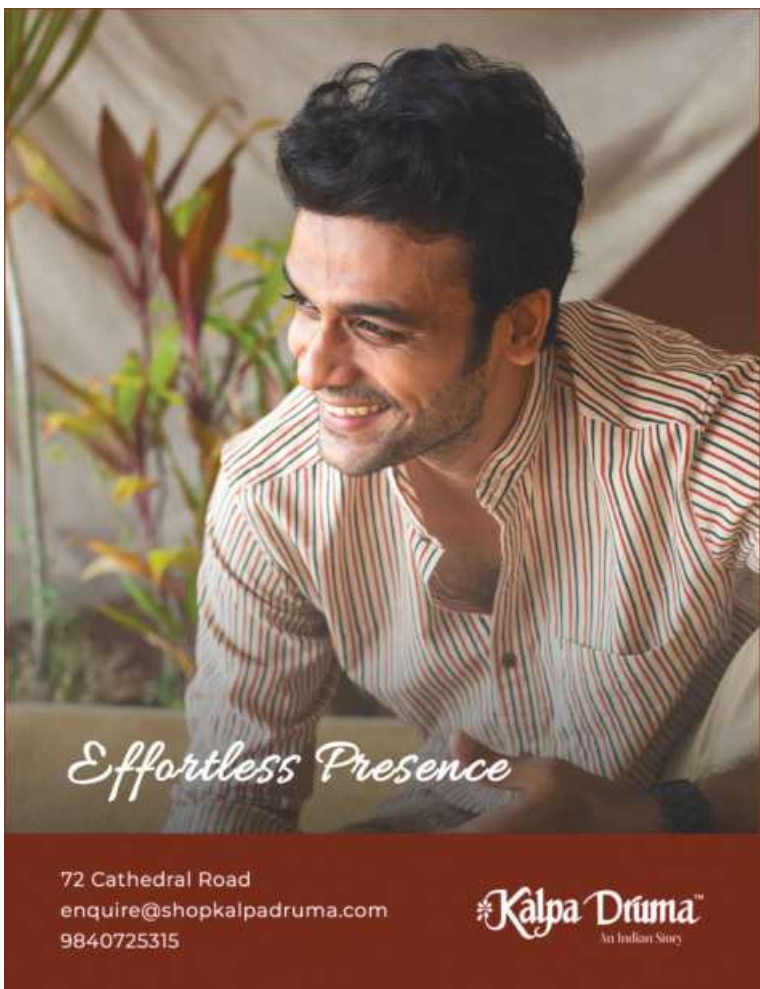
sequins too because I wanted the girl to look powerful while playing. You can also spot beaded embroidery, pearl embroidery, crochet and cutwork," says Maheka, adding that the capsule was created over a span of five months.

The collection plays with colourful stripes creating a palette that oscillates between turquoise, lime, pink, yellow and pastels. It comprises co-ord tracksuits, harem pants, shirtdresses, crochet pants, zipper pants, bolero jackets, straight dresses, oversized jackets and shirts with exaggerated sleeves. Though the mention of royalty brings to mind textured silhouettes and opulent textiles like silk and brocade, Maheka has relied heavily on French taffeta for this edit. One of the reasons is its tendency to absorb paint. "I have also used French organza, cotton, and linen. But taffeta is the best fabric. It's expensive, and you get it in beautiful colours. Taffeta is a bit stiff, so it gives me the kind of volume I want for exaggerated shoulders or cuffs. I have also fused crochet with denim because denim is light and easy," she explains. Another highlight of the collection is suspenders. In

Maharani Athleisure, they serve as a bulletin board for all the creative, edgy symbolism that defines Maheka's idea of boho. "I wanted to have suspenders because I feel they have got that masculinity but are also a must-have athleisure accessory. I have embroidered the suspenders. There's threadwork, buttons, safety pins, evil eye charm – I want it to be fun yet boho," she says. Though Indian fashion's interpretation



of royal-meets-athleisure started with Manish Arora's maximalist aesthetics, it is slowly carving a niche of its own, sometimes sharing the shelf with streetwear and on other occasions doing the tightrope between resortwear and ath-luxury. Maheka's Maharani Athleisure throws the ball in our court, inviting a sharper examination of where Indian athleisure is headed and how far it can stretch to absorb the codes of royalty. The collection, starting at ₹10,500, is available at Maheka Mirpuri Atelier, Mumbai, and on mahekamirpuri.com



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Hindi

Bizarre cases and bolder laughs



Anuj Kumar
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Delhi's Patparganj District Court is back in session, and this time the madness has escalated into full-blown judicial chaos. If the first season of *Maamla Legal Hai* proved that Indian district courtrooms can be funnier than a stand-up special, the second season takes the gavel and runs with it.

This time, showrunner Sameer Saxena and director Rahul Pandey flip the power dynamic – hustling lawyer VD Tyagi (Ravi Kishan) now embodies the system he once gamed. As Tyagi dons the Principal District Judge's robe, he de-starches the traditional image of the judiciary by replacing rigid formality and elitism with a high-energy, yet relatable, humanity. As Tyagi feels the weight of the gavel, the situation allows for sharper satire on judicial delays, bias, and the bureaucratic maze from the eyes of an insider.

Injecting life into the seemingly mundane struggles and aspirations of middle-class characters, the series once again centres on the everyday absurdities of life in a local court without getting repetitive. The show uses satire and black comedy to highlight serious loopholes in the Indian judicial system. Its format, where each episode often resolves a unique, sometimes bizarre case, evokes the charm of an era that slipped into soapy dramas. For instance, *Law* (Amit Pandey), *Order* (Vikram Pratap), and *Daleel* (Imran Rasheed) are not just personifications or wordplay on the elements of the judicial system; they become tangible metaphors of chaos in the courtroom.

Moreover, the series pokes fun at the systemic flaws, such as rats eating up case property in the evidence room, or judges always being on trial. The joke is usually on the absurdity of the system and social mores, not on the people trapped in them. Eventually, the series throws the question of capital punishment at Tyagi and the audience to grapple with.

Apart from crisp writing and sharp editing, it is the performances that do not make you feel the weight of watching eight episodes on the go. Ravi adroitly balances flamboyance with a deep level of control, knowing exactly how big a scene needs to be without making it feel laboured. Dinesh Lal Yadav (Nirahua), another star from the Bhojpuri cinescape, joins the cast and brings his comic timing to the ensemble, strengthening the show's connection with heartland viewers.

Maamla Legal Hai, despite being part of a recognisable template, maintains its emotional and intellectual honesty for the most part.

Maamla Legal Hai Season 2 is currently streaming on Netflix.



A predictable sports drama

Motocross gives a new turn to the familiar beats in director Abhilash Reddy's emotionally-steeped sports drama, and Sharwanand reclaims his spot under the sun

Telugu

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The broad contours of the storyline, sub plots and character arcs in director Abhilash Reddy's Telugu sports drama, *Biker* are familiar. Motocross, a sport that has rarely or perhaps never been explored in Indian cinema, gives it a new sheen. The cutting-edge audio-visual landscape and worthwhile performances make it fairly engaging.

At a time when the catchphrase 'world-building' is casually thrown around, and often limited to creating make-believe worlds aided by heavy use of visual effects, it is refreshing to watch a film unfold in real locations.

Biker follows a non-linear format of storytelling, moving between the 1990s, 2000s and occasionally the 80s, to present a story of two generations of fathers and sons. When the film opens with glimpses of an almost picture-perfect happy family – Vikas Narayan (Sharwanand), Ananya (Malvika Nair) and their young son, peppered with playful turns in school and home, it's endearing to witness. But an unmistakable question arises – where's the lie?

Abhilash peels back the layers to reveal strained family ties, with scars from the past that can heal only when a champion reclaims his throne.

The setting is Coimbatore, one of the cities where motocross thrives. While the film primarily revolves around Telugu-speaking people, it seamlessly uses multiple languages wherever required to maintain the authenticity.

In an early scene, when Vikas's young son, in a biker suit, declares that his father is his superhero and that he loved his father's motocross photograph from the past, it's hard to not think of Gowtam Tinnanuri's *Jersey*. Abhilash tips his hat to that celebrated sports drama through several moments, almost as though intending his film to its spiritual successor. Simultaneously, he also draws thematically from his debut web-series *Loser* (a sports

Biker

Director: Director: Abhikash Reddy Kankara

Cast: Sharwanand, Malvika Nair, Rajashekhar, Atul Kulkarni

Storyline: A son returns to restore his father's honour. Considerable time has passed and a lot is at stake. Can he do it?

and family drama) and debut feature film *Maa Nanna Superhero*, a father-son story.

Biker is a more masala-laden, commercial outing than *Jersey*. Yet, the multiple relationship threads give the story the required emotional gravitas. The writing shines more through the characters than the broad storyline. The unquestioning admiration that the young boy has for Vikas is an echo of the respect that Vikas has for his father-coach Sunil (Dr Rajashekhar). Parallely, there's the less-explored but relevant bond between Vikas's arch rival and his father. The bond between Vikas and Ananya and the upheavels it goes through, as parenthood tempers brute courage with caution and practicality, is yet another nod to *Jersey*. Then there's the bond between Ananya and her mother (Tulasi).

Many of these characters also have their own, reasonably-etched individual arcs. Take Tulasi's characterisation, for instance. There's no melodrama when she learns of something that could appear unsettling in the 90s. In her limited screentime, she makes her presence felt by being a stoic support and nudging Ananya to look beyond her own fear in a pivotal scene. And Ananya is also not written like a pushover. The film may largely be about fathers and sons, their adrenaline-packed sports, and there's still room for Ananya to assert herself– pursuing her profession of choice and having her say in crucial moments. All these characters and the emotionally-laden sub plots serve to make the motocross segments absorbing enough. The racing circuit and the manoeuvre of the bikers are filmed with finesse, with cinematography led by Yuvaraj and the sound department (sound design by Sync Cinema and mixing by Kannan Ganpath) keeping us glued to the proceedings.

The shift in motocross from the 90s, when two-stroke bikes ruled, to the four-stroke bikes of the 2000s, work well to show how a biker has to adapt to prove himself.

During the pre-release interview, Abhilash had revealed that the motocross portions were filmed in Indonesia, but they have tried to appear authentic to the Coimbatore terrain. For anyone familiar with Coimbatore and its proximity to the

hills of Kerala as well as Nilgiris, some portions work and in others, the cinematic liberty is evident. Yet, it isn't a deterrant. While *Biker* has plenty of racing moments and even an improbable leap of faith, the deft touch lies in how the story uses that daring act as a narrative tool when it matters the most.

If there's a sorethumb, it has to do with the characterisation of a corporate bigwig, played by Atul Kulkarni. The actor does not miss a beat and plays it to the hilt, but the part itself could have been more nuanced. The same goes for the sidekicks who accompany him. An early song and dance number featuring the lead pair is also a needless speedbreaker.

Several smaller moments – like a fleeting poster of *Thalapathy*, a screening of *Baashha*, a passing mention of a textile mill (a nod to Coimbatore and its successful textile mills of yore) sponsoring a race, work as markers of the 90s. The transition of time is subtly underlined through the Simba-Mufasa visuals from *The Lion King* of 2003.

Ghibran's background score transitions between the decades, each with a different tempo and rhythm. Ghibran also knows when to let silence work its magic – it speaks volumes in a few moments between Vikas and Sunil. In another scene, the glances exchanged between Vikas and Anwar do the needful.

A story with high emotional stakes gets ample support from its actors. *Biker* marks the return to form for Sharwanand, after a string of middling films. Given a solid story and a character, his restrained performance packs a punch. Then there's Malvika Nair, who quietly emotes through her eyes and lights up the screen with her presence. Dr Rajashekhar is mostly required to be stoic and a reference to his 'angry young man' image of the 80s and 90s elicits cheers.

As an aside, the film is peppered with several mentions of 'loser', almost as a callback to Abhilash's web series.

On the whole, *Biker* is an engaging watch. Had it pushed itself to go beyond predictable turns, it could have been a standout film.

Biker is currently running in theatres

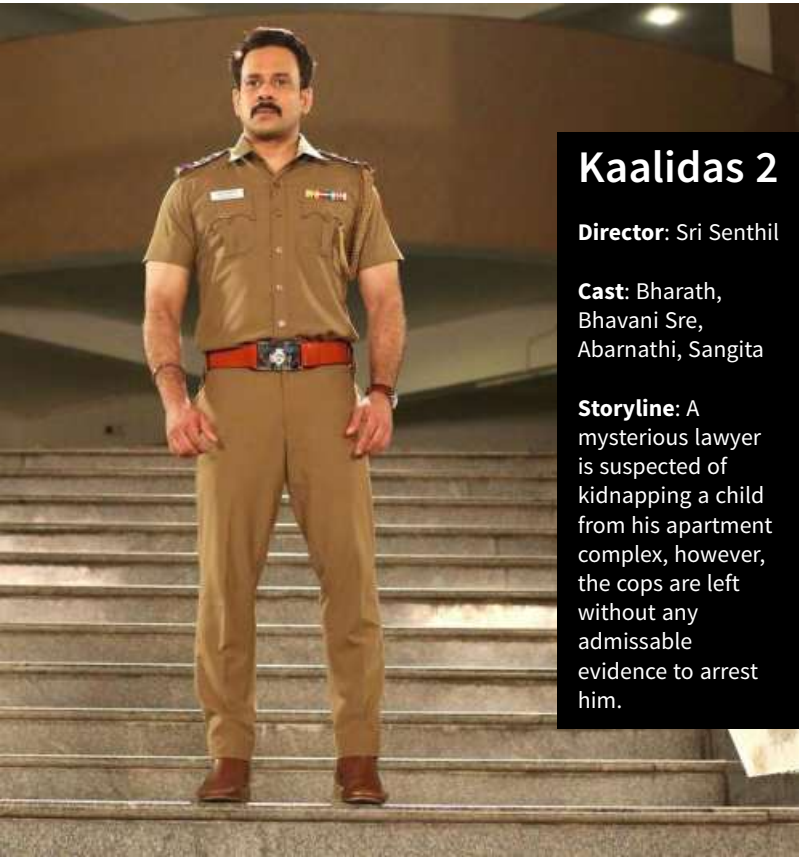
One good twist cannot save this tedious thriller

Tamil

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The experience of watching a thriller is like being handed over a strong cup of coffee – it can either jolt you awake or leave you cold; anything in the middle is forgettable. That I craved for a strong cup of coffee after watching an evening show of *Kaalidas 2* should tell one about its effec. This Sri Senthil directorial starring Bharath, falls under a particular style of thriller filmmaking that Tamil cinema is all the more familiar with. A straightforward crime story, which, when linearly told, might present the closest we have to objective truth, is segmented into bits that are purposely rearranged and stylised in a very specific pattern to throw a twist around every corner. However, as it often might happen, the final picture might just expose the whole exercise as a tad too contrived, or even manipulative.

Not only is that the case here, but



Kaalidas 2

Director: Sri Senthil

Cast: Bharath, Bhavani Sre, Abarnathi, Sangita

Storyline: A mysterious lawyer is suspected of kidnapping a child from his apartment complex, however, the cops are left without any admissable evidence to arrest him.

Kaalidas 2 also meanders and takes too much effort to piece together the jigsaw. Too many things are happening before we get to the conflict. Inspector Kaalidas (Bharath) goes solo in an attempt to save a married couple in Meyyur from goons, only to find them already hacked to death by the woman's father. How does this tie to the larger plot? Even psychologically, this does very little to drive Kaalidas. Now, who is this young lawyer named Stephen (Ajay Karthi) who kidnaps a gangster from court and kills him? We are given only a hurried hint of a gang war between rival gangsters.

Soon, Stephen moves to a new apartment in Urupakkam, where he stalks Gokul (Anant Nag), his wife Sanju (Abarnathi), and their child Mithra. Everything changes on the night of the New Year celebrations, when Mithra, whom we last saw following Stephen's pet dog, goes missing. Kaalidas is called to solve the case.

There's a visible instability in the setup of the plot that never allows *Kaalidas 2* to establish an atmosphere and set a tempo for itself. The writing

sees a visible dip after Assistant Commissioner Vaishnavi (Bhavani Sre) takes over as the head of the investigation team. This is an IPS officer who, not only has the patience of a toddler, but also often throws tantrums like one, making you wonder if she really had any IPS training. *Kaalidas 2* is certainly one of the most recent films to feature such dull-witted cops.

The second half, especially, meanders so much that *Kaalidas 2* begins to test your patience. In the midst of the constantly annoying Vaishnavi, a revenge plot featuring Kishore and Prakash Raj's cameos, and a dull character like Stephen with no convincing logic to his behaviour, we have Kaalidas, who takes his sweet time to rise to the occasion with his detection skills.

You certainly do not foresee the twist in the climax, but that is not to say that it would leave you with a better aftertaste. You begin to question the necessity of many of the characters and their elaborate subplots, when in fact, a leaner narrative would have made it a crisp and effective whodunit.

The first *Kaalidas* was a no-frills thriller, content with the small world its characters operated in. In fact, when Suresh Chandra Menon's character appears briefly in the sequel, you expect him to return to help with the police procedural, or to see what happened to Kaalidas after the events of the first film. But except for a dialogue and a passing detail that he is living with his mother, the film is too busy to care about the character progression of the franchise's titular hero.

The first film too had a similar twist towards the end, but every character served the story and not merely the final reveal. The sequel, which comes with a bigger canvas, cast and production value, comes across as an empty shell that's too desperate to impress. Which is why even Sam CS's remix of Bharathiyar's 'Chinnanchiru Kiliye' in the climax fails to move you.

By the end of it all, you are only left craving a strong cup of coffee – one that has more kick than the film.

Kaalidas 2 is currently running in theatres

The Super Mario Galaxy Movie

Directors: Aaron Horvath, Michael Jelenic

Starring: Chris Pratt, Anya Taylor-Joy, Charlie Day, Jack Black, Keegan-Michael Key, Benny Safdie, Donald Glover, Brie Larson

Storyline: Mario and friends go to outer space to rescue Princess Rosalina and face off against Bowser and Bowser Jr



All action, little imagination

English

Mini Anthikad Chhibber

There is so much hectic action on screen that one cannot hear oneself think, which is somewhat of a good thing, as *The Super Mario Galaxy Movie* does not offer anything radically new in terms of story.

The Super Mario Galaxy Movie is based on Nintendo's 2007 video game, *Super Mario Galaxy*.

Princess Rosalina (Brie Larson), the adoptive mother of the star-shaped Lumas, is kidnapped by Bowser Jr. (Benny Safdie) to prove once and for all that he is worthy of his villain dad, Bowser

(Jack Black), the king of the turtle-like Koopas.

Princess Peach (Anya Taylor-Joy), the ruler of the Mushroom Kingdom, has shrunk Bowser and imprisoned him in her castle. Mario (Chris Pratt) and his brother Luigi (Charlie Day) are in charge of Bowser's rehabilitation, which is not going too well since he still has anger issues, though he is growing incrementally closer to the brothers.

The brothers, while investigating a disturbance in a desert, befriend the green dinosaur Yoshi (Donald Glover). At Peach's birthday celebrations, she tells Mario, who has feelings for her but is afraid to voice them, that she does not know where she came from.

When a Luma crashlands at the party and tells of Princess Rosalina's

kidnapping, Mario and the gang go to the rescue. They are helped on their quest by a mercenary space pilot, Fox McCloud (Glen Powell), and a bored honey bee queen (Issa Rae) from Honeyhive Galaxy.

Fans of the game will enjoy the Easter eggs and callbacks and there is enough frenetic action, and colours for those completely new to the world of Italian-American plumbers from Brooklyn and blond princesses.

The movie portrays a bunch of relationships, including father-son (Bowser and Jr) and sibling (Peach and Rosalina) arcs, but then loses interest and leaves them stranded. The same goes for Powell's piratical McCloud, which is a terrible shame.

The voice work is competent, with Black and Pratt giving their 110%. The action sequences, especially when the brothers are left in charge of the Mushroom Kingdom and plant flags as they battle threats, are reminiscent of the game, as is the Super Scope that turns

Mario, Luigi, and the tyrannosaur into babies. The chase over the dinosaur bridge in Fossil Falls is pretty cool. The sequence where Peach and her anthropomorphic mushroom sidekick Toad (Keegan-Michael Key) breach the crime boss Wart's (Luis Guzmán) casino bends reality in the nicest possible way bringing to mind the room and not the camera that moved in Jamiroquai's 'Virtual Insanity' music video.

There is a lot of running, catching, falling, and jumping, which gets exhausting after a while. There is practically no humour in a film that is supposed to be a comedy. However, it would keep the *bachcha* party engrossed, and parents can take the precious 90 minutes on offer for shut-eye in air-conditioned comfort.

The Super Mario Galaxy Movie is currently running in theatres.

Snippets



Ahaan Panday starts shooting for his next with Ali Abbas Zafar

Actor Ahaan Panday, who became a breakout star with Mohit Suri's *Saiyaara*, has started shooting for his next with Ali Abbas Zafar. The currently untitled romantic-actioner, backed by Yash Raj Films, also stars Sharvati, Aaishvarya Thackeray and Bobby Deol in pivotal roles.

Ali, known for helming *Tiger Zinda Hai* and *Sultan*, made the announcement today giving a sneak peek into Ahaan's look in the film, who is seen donning a fierce look in his eyes. Sharing the photo, Ali wrote, "And it BEGINS."

More details about the plot and release date about the film remain under wraps.

Ali's last directorial was the Akshay Kumar and Tiger Shroff starrer *Bade Miyan Chote Miyan*.



Vir Das to helm and star in horror film, Baara Number

Following his maiden directorial debut *Happy Patel: Khatarnak Jasoos*, Vir Das is set to explore a new creative space with his next project. Vir announced that his next is a found footage horror film, titled *Baara Number*, which he will co-direct with Kavi Shastri.

The film is set to go on floors in June with its initial shooting schedule planned in Mumbai. Vir will also feature as part of a multi-character cast.

As per a press release, the film is aimed to move beyond conventional tropes, "blending psychological depth with atmospheric storytelling". It has been in development for a long time.



Rajkummar Rao starts shooting for Saurav Ganguly biopic

Actor Rajkummar Rao has started shooting for *Dada*, the biopic on the life of cricketing legend Saurav Ganguly, the makers announced on April 2. The film is being helmed by Vikramaditya Motwane and produced by Luv Ranjan and Ankuar Garg under Luv Films.

The makers shared a photo of the clapperboard on social media to make the announcement. "Lights, Camera, Cricket! 'Dada' Filming Begins Now," wrote Luv Films in caption.

Motwane also shared a photo of the Sourav Ganguly stand from Eden Gardens stadium in Kolkata on social media and wrote in caption, "Take your seats."



A crackling, edgy romance

Kristoffer Borgli brings an audacious twist in the traditional romance in a film that is aided by a remarkable play of performances between Robert Pattinson and Zendaya

English

Shreyas Pande

Her name is Emma (Zendaya), his name is Charlie (Robert Pattinson), and just like any other couple, the two have their meet-cute moment at a bustling cafe in New York. With a jollier-than-thou first date where emotions are unmasked, an instinctive first kiss post-midnight at the Manhattan museum, and a marriage proposal whispered straight to her damaged ear—their story has the perfect setup for an endearing wedding day speech, just like any other romance-for-the-ages. There is only a wholesome promise in *The Drama* in the opening portions, until the surface beneath the surface begins to sneak in. It's not for nothing that the title of the book Emma reads when they first meet is *The Damage* as he pretends to have read it. The metaphors speak for themselves further as an explosive secret from her past blows up during a conversation. The collapse of their intimate dream has parallels with the rapture of the American dream. What's personal gets messy and political. This is not like any other love story after all.

Norwegian filmmaker Kristoffer Borgli frames the early moments in his edgy dark comedy with a frantic dissonance, employing sublime jump cuts to move across timelines and bring a sense of jarring unease to the fairytale of Emma and Charlie. The breathless juxtaposition also produces humour that relies as much on the placement of these cuts as it does on the sharpness of the dialogues.

It is only when the secret is revealed that Borgli adds a sense of calm to the writing in what is among the longest scenes in the film, which takes place at a restaurant over a few wine bottles in the presence of Charlie's friend, Mike

The Drama

Director: Kristoffer Borgli

Cast: Robert Pattinson, Zendaya, Mamoudou Athie and Alana Haim

Synopsis: A young couple is counting days until their marriage when a disturbing secret from the girl's past complicates their bond

(Mamoudou Athie), and his partner, Rachel (Alana Haim). The nature of the conversation turns quite smoothly to all of them describing the worst things they have done in life, where a terribly drunk Emma is pressured to share her story from the time when she was fifteen and dreamt of doing a mass shooting in her school. Expectedly, the mood shifts, and the film has a change of heart.

Borgli is not new to these tonal shifts, having previously made off-beat, absurdist and surreal pieces with *Sick of Myself* (2022) and *Dream Scenario* (2024). However, he builds an audacious premise with *The Drama*. On one side, it mirrors interpersonal concerns of how well you know someone you love and how far will you go on accepting them for what they were. Borgli touches upon these when a devastated Charlie confronts Emma with pointed questions about why she fantasised about guns, what made her not do it and so on. In these portions, the film takes on a documentary-like rigour to understand the psychology of Emma and many like her, who grew up as wounded children in a polarised country. It is all filmed with sensitivity, mingling rather smoothly with the changing dynamics between Emma and Charlie, knowing when to pull back from its ironical overlays and cast an eye of empathy.

There's still a lot that goes unsaid as Borgli largely uses the political overtures to complicate the tension between the lovers. He chooses political awareness over political consciousness, making the entire ordeal feel like just another dimension to Emma's psyche. It remains an incisive idea that gets lost in the muddle, in what could have attained a similar, pressing bolt as that of Jordan Peele's *Get Out* (2017) and *Us* (2019) or even Ryan Coogler's *Sinners*. These films flew in through a popular genre with a larger purpose while Borgli uses the political flourishes to take us back to Emma and Charlie.

Which also turns out to be its fitting

course. Borgli's insistence on treating the film as a traditional romance has its powerfully crackling moments, leading to an emotionally affecting climax that beautifully brings in a call-back to an earlier scene, leaving us with an aching resolution. Even through all seriousness, the humour stays intact, lending the film a strange pull of a tragic-comedy. The editing remains inventive, as seen in a transition from a conversation about gun shooting to a chirpy photographer enthusiastically listing all the family members she plans to shoot at the wedding. It is also a scene that is as immaculately performed by Pattinson and Zendaya, as they hide under the pretence of 'the normal', but can't bring themselves to pose as per the instructions given by the photographer.

Pattinson enters Charlie with the charm of a dreamy lover-boy, only to slowly embody his disintegration with a precipitous palpability where his doubts and frustrations are instantly humanised. Zendaya complements his hysterics with a composed reckoning, breaking into a flurry of enigma at times while maintaining a certain mystery in her being otherwise.

Their remarkable performances add a lot of bite to the story, often creating moments of wondrous romance in a carefully devised dance sequence or the decaying love reflected through conflicted eye glances and dispirited gestures. It is love that brought Emma and Charlie together, and a country's state of affairs that threatened to make them into strangers. That's why Emma's past (and America's history) couldn't just remain their ugly secret; it is bound to come out in the open, leave bruises and blood, and continue to shape the future of their present. Can they start over? Certainly, but only when the nation heals its wounding core. Without that, there's no love in this story; without that, it will forever remain not-like-any-other.

The Drama is currently running in theatres.